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THE HISTORY OF LATIN AMERICA COLLISION OF CULTURES

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The Lay of the Land—and the Water

Tens of millions of years before the dramatic clashes of peoples that gave birth to Latin American cultures and societies, the almost imperceptible collisions of enormous tectonic plates forged the landmasses of what we now call the Americas. The physical features of Mexico, Central America, the Caribbean, and South America have emerged out of the encounters of six massive tectonic slabs or plates drifting imperceptibly across the surface of the Earth. For hundreds of millions of years the landmasses that we recognize today as continents have been slowly migrating across the face of the Earth—separating, drifting, and colliding. Around 600 million years ago, "South America" lay on the opposite side of the globe in an "upside-down" position, forming part of a collection of landmasses known to geologists as Gondwanaland. Some 400 million years later, all of the modern continents had rammed together, creating a single landmass known as Pangea. What today is the northeastern "bulge" of Brazil jutting into the Atlantic was nestled up against the lands that now constitute the coast of the Bight of Benin in West Africa, and the southern coastline of South America stretched out alongside the African coastline from modern-day Nigeria to South Africa. "North America" was nestled up against the northwestern coast of the African continent and southwestern Europe, at the entrance of what today is the Mediterranean.

At the end of the geological age known as the Jurassic period (about 135 to 100 million years ago), the North American and South American landmasses had begun to slide to the west as Pangea gradually split apart. The space between the two continents opened up, initiating the formation

of what would become the Gulf of Mexico and the North Atlantic Ocean. As South America and Africa separated, the South Atlantic also began to take shape. Between 90 and 60 million years ago, North and South America had begun to move closer together, near their present locations. As the two enormous plates migrated westward, they collided with the Cocos Plate in the gap between the two continents. This geological confrontation thrust the islands of the Greater Antilles upward, in the region now occupied by Central America. The Cocos Plate continued pressing up against the North American and Caribbean Plates while sliding down and under the Caribbean Plate to the east. This collision sheared apart the largest piece of the Greater Antilles, creating Cuba and Hispaniola and gradually pushed the islands into their present locations. It also thrust upward Central America as a land bridge between North and South America, while forming the Gulf of Mexico and the Caribbean Sea. As these three plates pushed up against each other, they also created a series of volcanic arcs along their edges, through southern Mexico, Central America, and across the Lesser Antilles. The colliding plates produced a violent venting of molten magma creating the classic volcanic cones in central Mexico—Orizaba, Popocatepetl, and Ixtacihuatl—rising some 17,000 to 19,000 feet above sea level.

The collision of tectonic plates was even more violent in western South America. Beginning about 15 million years ago, and continuing for some 10 million years, the Nazca Plate pushed eastward up against the South American Plate, creating extraordinary volcanic activity that gave birth to the various ranges of the Andes along the length of western South America. This continuing collision warped, folded, and thrust the crust of the Earth upward, forming spectacular mountains second only to the Himalayas in altitude. The Andean range is rarely more than 200 miles wide (except in Bolivia where its width doubles), and the highest peaks range from 18,000 to nearly 23,000 feet. (Mt. Aconcagua on the Argentine-Chilean border is the highest peak in the Americas at 22,835 feet above sea level.) The continuing eastward movement of the Cocos, Nazca, and Antarctic Plates up against the west coast of Latin America produces constant volcanic instability from Mexico to southern Chile. The earthquakes that have devastated Latin American cities since the sixteenth century are but the most recent episodes in millions of years of geological instability produced by the continuing movement of these plates.

When the human species began to emerge hundreds of thousands of years ago, the shifting tectonic plates had already given form to the continents as we know them today. The Americas, North and South, are two enormous landmasses (stretching from nearly the North to the South Pole) connected by the Central American isthmus and the islands of the Caribbean. Each continent covers about eight million square miles, and

combined they account for one-quarter of the Earth's land surface. They are separated from Asia by the vast Pacific Ocean, except at the northernmost point where the narrow stretch of waters in the Bering Strait flows between Siberia and Alaska. For millions of years the equally enormous Atlantic Ocean formed a formidable barrier between the Americas, Europe, and Africa, with the large islands of Greenland and Iceland serving as stepping stones across the waters in the far north.

Today, Latin America spans some 7,000 miles (roughly the distance from northern Finland to South Africa) from the Rio Grande to Cape Horn, across more than 60 degrees of latitude. Most of the people in the region, however, live in the 40 degrees of latitude between the Tropic of Cancer and the Tropic of Capricorn. (The tropics in the Americas are called the "neotropics" by scientists.) At its widest east-west axis, from Peru to the Brazilian bulge, South America spans some 3,200 miles (roughly the distance from San Francisco to Nova Scotia). As Jared Diamond has pointed out in his Pulitzer-prize-winning book *Guns, Germs, and Steel*, the enormous extension of Latin America (and Africa) on a north-south axis across such great distances has profoundly shaped its history and development. The vast, hot lowlands of Central and South America acted as barriers to the spread of crops and livestock as they were domesticated in the temperate uplands of central Mexico and the Andes. Unlike the peoples of Europe, the United States, and the core of Asia, the peoples of Latin America and Africa have had to contend with much greater diversity in their environments, and greater challenges to movement across these environments. The end result in both Africa and the Americas was the much later and slower development and diffusion of agriculture capable of sustaining more complex societies and civilizations. The peoples of the Northern Hemisphere, especially in the Old World and in North America, have moved along an east-west axis through roughly similar climatic zones, facilitating the spread of "development" (to use a modern term).

The enormous geological and latitude range have shaped the formation of a wide variety of geographic and climatic zones across Latin America. Geographers have divided up the region into Middle America (Mexico, Central America, and the West Indies) and South America. (To be very precise, geographically, North America ends at the Isthmus of Tehuantepec in Southern Mexico and South America begins at the Isthmus of Panama, with Central America in between.) The two most impressive physical features of all the Americas are enormous mountains and large river systems. From the Alaskan Arctic down through the western United States, Mexico, Central America, and western South America, two lines of mountain ranges—thrust upward from the age-old pressure of the Pacific tectonic plates pressing up against the continents—form the backbone of the Americas, North and South. In the western United States and Mexico,

the Rocky Mountains and the Sierra Madre Mountains define much of the region. Between the Rockies and the Pacific Mountains along the West Coast are plateaus and desert basins extending from Canada down into central Mexico, wrapping around the Sierra Madres. Several smaller mountain ranges through southern Mexico and Central America dominate the landscape. Geological instability and frequent volcanic activity have scarred the region and made its peoples "sons and daughters of the shaking earth" (to steal Eric Wolf's beautiful phrase). The Andean chain of mountains has two branches in northern South America, one beginning in Panama and the other in western Venezuela. Both converge in central Colombia and two roughly parallel ranges extend down through Ecuador, Peru, Bolivia, western Argentina, and Chile. Although there are true coastal lowlands in western Colombia and Ecuador, the coastal plain from northern Peru to southern Chile is often very narrow and arid. In contrast with the young and rugged Andes, the eastern highlands of South America are old and worn down. The Amazon basin splits them into two large pieces. To the north are the Guiana Highlands or Shield, and to the south the highlands that cover much of eastern Brazil. Both sets of mountains gradually decline in altitude as they move inland, eventually disappearing into the Amazonian lowlands. At their highest points (in the east), the Guiana and Brazilian Highlands reach only a few thousand feet above sea level.

If the Pacific mountain ranges form the backbone of Latin America, the great river systems are its arteries. Stretching more than 4,000 miles from its source in the Peruvian Andes until it empties into the Atlantic, the Amazon is the greatest of all the rivers of the Americas, dwarfing even the mighty Mississippi River. More than 15 miles across at some points, it reaches depths of 250 feet, deeper than any other river in the world. The early explorers were so impressed with this river, with its volume of water eight times that of the Mississippi, that they called it a river-sea. The Amazon River Valley consists of some 25,000 miles of rivers and streams draining much of the interior of South America. With the Andes to the west, and the Guiana and Brazilian Highlands to the northeast and southeast, the Amazon is something of a giant funnel system channeling waters from the interior into the equatorial Atlantic. To the north and south of the Amazon lie two more great river systems, the Orinoco and the Paraná. Both river systems originate in the interior of the continent. The Orinoco winds eastward through northern South America for some 1,600 miles, emptying into the Atlantic on the northeastern coast via an enormous delta that begins some 250 miles inland. The Paraná-Paraguay basin drains the interior of South America and spans parts of Bolivia, Brazil, Paraguay, Argentina, and Uruguay. The two rivers converge near the Argentine city of Corrientes, eventually joining the Río de la Plata and

then flowing into the South Atlantic. Unlike the Mississippi in temperate North America, these three great river systems of South America have been sparsely inhabited and undeveloped tropical frontiers for centuries. The great rivers of South America have never been the thriving transportation axes of development like the Mississippi, the Nile, the Yangtze, or the Indus. Equally important, the great population centers of Latin America since pre-Columbian times—Mexico, Central America, the Andes—have no significant river systems. It is one of the great ironies of the geography of Latin America that where there are great rivers there are few people, and where there are many people there are no great rivers.

The densest populations in Latin America developed in the temperate highlands of central Mexico and the Andes. In central Mexico, civilization emerged in the valleys at altitudes of 6,000 to 9,000 feet. In the Andes, populations were much more fragmented in the mountain valleys with the high plain (*altiplano*) in Bolivia bordering Lake Titicaca playing a role similar to the Valley of Mexico. The *altiplano*, however, is above 10,000 feet and much colder and more arid than the Valley of Mexico. The cool highlands of Mexico and the Andes became the two great centers for the emergence of agriculture in the New World with the domestication of maize in Mesoamerica and the potato in the Andes. The tropical lowlands of eastern South America produced the third area where food production arose independently, in this case, around the domestication of the tuber known as manioc or cassava. Despite the dispersal of food cultivation across much of tropical America, the lowlands of South America never developed dense populations. The interior lowlands of South America form its "empty heart," in the words of one geographer. In pre-Columbian times, much of the interior lowlands and the coastal plains of eastern South America were covered by forest and jungle, as was much of the Caribbean basin, both the islands and the coastal mainland.

While latitude and altitude contribute to the great diversity of climatic zones in Latin America, this variety is also shaped by wind systems and the influence of the surrounding oceans and seas. In the lowland tropical regions the general rule is high rainfall and hot temperatures, with little variation in temperature range. Despite its popular image, temperatures in the Amazon average only in the high eighties, and rarely fluctuate more than ten degrees higher or lower. The temperature range is much greater in the mountains, dropping to freezing levels on the Bolivian *altiplano*. As one old saying goes, "Night is the winter of the tropics." The warm South Equatorial Current feeds into the Caribbean Sea and the Gulf of Mexico, helping create hot cauldrons of water. As the northeast trade winds sweep across the Caribbean from June to October, the air becomes hot, moist, and volatile, creating the hurricanes that plague the region. The hot, moist air masses moving into South America from the equatorial Atlantic provide

the enormous rainfall that characterizes the Amazon River Valley. Moderate ocean temperatures in the South Atlantic help create subtropical to warm temperatures through southern Brazil, Paraguay, Uruguay, and northern Argentina. In the Pacific, contending currents clash. The Equatorial Counter Current flows eastward before splitting north toward Central America and south toward Ecuador and Peru. It brings warm, moist air and rain to southern Central America. From the north, the cool California Current helps insure moderate temperatures in western Mexico. From the south, the cold Peru Current flows upward from Chile. As the mild winds from the south Pacific pass over this cold water, they cannot absorb moisture and the result is arid conditions along the South American coast. In the Atacama Desert in northern Chile, there are areas where no rainfall has ever been recorded. Every three to seven years, the ocean along the western coast of South America reaches unusually warm levels, normally beginning around December. Known as El Niño ("the Christ child"), this warming reverses normal wind flows and brings enormous rainfall and flooding to South America, especially the desert regions of Peru.

The enormous variations in latitude, altitude, rainfall, and temperature have produced an astonishing array of flora and fauna throughout Latin America. In the tropical lowlands of the Caribbean and eastern South America, the change of "seasons" is largely confined to a wet season and a dry season, creating lush and fertile environments for flora that flourish year-round. The tropical forests of Amazonia are home to the most diverse collection of plant and animal species on the planet. At the other extreme, the deserts of northern Mexico and the Pacific coast of South America are arid and hostile to the proliferation of both flora and fauna. These deserts, however, have some of the richest mineral deposits in the world, including silver, nitrates, and copper. Altitude shapes the ecology of the mountains. At higher elevations in the Andes, the terrain is barren and arid. In both Mesoamerica and the Andes, civilizations have flourished at altitudes from 3,000 to 13,000 feet, exploiting the rich volcanic soils of Central America and the melting snow in the Andes. In some mountainous regions (like Costa Rica), tropical latitudes and altitude have produced an enormous array of ecological zones in very small areas. Costa Rica is home to about 800 species of birds, more species than are found in all of North America.

Geography and geological history, especially the isolation of the New World from the Old, have also profoundly shaped the flora and fauna of Latin America. When the Europeans arrived in 1492, the Americas had no cattle, horses, oxen, or camels—in short, no significant beasts of burden. (A species of prehistoric horse had died out thousands of years before 1492.) The alpacas and llamas of the Andes were the closest thing to

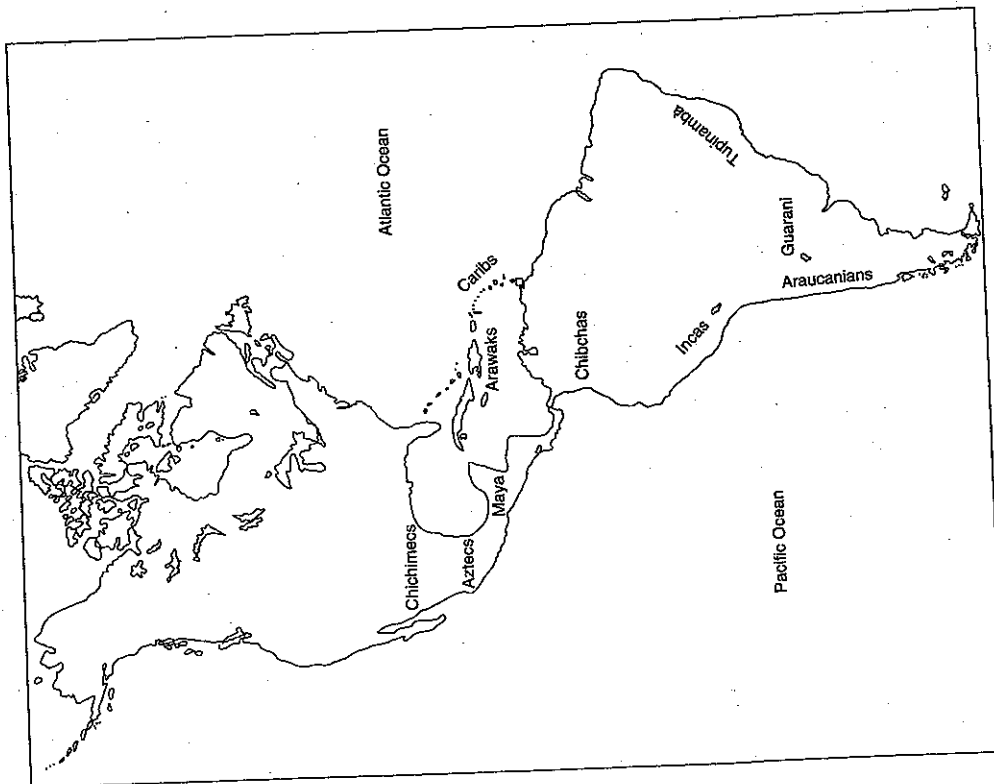
a beast of burden, but ones that refuse to carry more than 80 kilograms. The largest beasts in Latin America were tapirs in the tropical lowlands. Jaguars and mountain lions were the largest predators. Over thousands of years, the crops emerged that would feed most Native Americans, and that were native only to the Americas: maize in Mesoamerica, cassava in the Caribbean and Amazonian lowlands, the potato in the Andes. Chile peppers, pineapples, cacao (chocolate), and tobacco are just a few of the American flora that were unknown in the Old World. (Imagine an Old World before 1492 with no tobacco, no chocolate, and no readily available form of sugar!)

Just as it is difficult to speak of Latin America as a cultural unit, the extraordinary diversity of climates, geographic zones, and physical features make the region even more complex. Again, although geography is not destiny, we should keep in mind the underlying geographical features of the various regions of Latin America as its history unfolds. Small tropical islands, for example, will operate under serious constraints, compared to the fertile lands of southern South America or the enormous mineral resources of Mexico. These very diverse geographical and geological features played, and continue to play, a key role in the development and underdevelopment of the countries of Latin America.

2

American Peoples and Cultures

The "first Americans" arrived in a series of migrations from the Asian continent across the Bering Strait possibly as far back as 40,000 years ago. The last wave of migrants was the Eskimo, or Inuit, who traveled across the frozen expanses of the Arctic about 4,000 years ago. Archaeologists have long debated the dates of the earliest arrivals, with more traditional and conservative scholars arguing against any clear proof of migration before about 12,000 years ago. Although not an archaeologist, I believe there is growing and convincing evidence, especially from Chile, that the dates should be pushed back to at least 20,000 years ago. All agree, however, that by 10,000 years ago humans occupied most of the Americas from Canada to Terra del Fuego. The islands of the Caribbean and the plains of southern South America were probably the last major regions to be populated, only about 2,000 years before the arrival of Columbus. In contrast to the striking diversity of their languages and cultures, Native Americans were extraordinarily homogenous in genetic or biological terms. (The blood type of most Native Americans, for example, is O, a type common to more than 80 percent of them.) For reasons that are not entirely clear, these early migrants did not bring with them the diseases of the Old World. (Some have hypothesized that the cold Arctic passage served as a sort of "filter," killing off dangerous microbes.) None of the Native American populations had exposure to diseases that ravaged the Old World: influenza, smallpox, measles, malaria, yellow fever, plague, typhus. For this lack of exposure and immunity, they would pay a very high price during the European invasion and conquest.



Map 2. Major Indigenous Groups before 1492

We do not know with any great certainty how many people lived in the Americas in 1492. A long and ongoing debate has led to widely divergent estimates of the indigenous population prior to the European conquest. Estimates range from as low as 25 million to as high as 125 million. Most specialists would probably put the figure somewhere around 50 to 75 million. The most densely populated regions were Mesoamerica (central Mexico to northern Costa Rica), with a population possibly as high as 25 to 30 million, and the Andes, with some 10 to 15 million inhabitants. Estimates for other regions are highly unreliable and largely guesses. For 1550, for example, the usual guesses are from one to five million people in North America and the same estimate for Brazil. At the moment of European contact, over 350 major tribal groups, divided into more than 150 major linguistic groups, spread across the Americas.

When Columbus arrived in the Caribbean in 1492, he believed that he had reached the "Indies," something of a generic term for Asia in his day. He called the natives "*indios*" and this word stuck, entering into the vocabulary of many languages. The term "Native Americans" has gained wide acceptance in the last few decades, but it is also problematic. The term "America" is also Eurocentric. It is a name given to the New World by a German cartographer in the early sixteenth century to honor Amerigo Vespucci, one of the best-known early explorers. I will use these terms interchangeably. Most native groups before the Conquest simply called themselves "the people" and they saw the rest of the peoples around them as the "Other," to use the parlance of contemporary academics. There is no "politically correct" term to employ here. One of the most radical groups of the 1970s, for example, was called the American Indian Movement. One growing movement now promotes the term "indigenous peoples." From my perspective, it is one of the great ironies of the early twenty-first century that the term "Indian" has now become a generic label adopted by native peoples all across the Americas to create a sense of solidarity. In effect, they have accepted the lumping of all native peoples together, something the Europeans artificially did in the sixteenth century to peoples with no sense of common identity or solidarity.

Although this is the standard story of the peopling of the Americas, controversies have challenged this narrative in recent decades. Some (most prominently, Ivan van Sertima, a linguist at Rutgers University) have argued for the key role of African migrants in the rise of American civilizations. Others (such as the Scandinavian anthropologist, Thor Heyerdahl) have made the case for transpacific voyages. Ironically, the trouble with these theories is that they produce a mirror image of the racism of the nineteenth-century European scholars who attempted to explain the origins of the great pre-Columbian ruins of Mesoamerica and the Andes in this way. They believed that the native peoples of the Americas were too ignorant and unfit to have produced what were clearly the remains of

incredibly sophisticated civilizations. They theorized that these cultures must have originated from transatlantic voyages by the Greeks, the Egyptians, or the lost tribes of Israel. The theories that Africans provided the origins of the great Native American civilizations make the same mistake, reversing the racial bias of the nineteenth century from "white" to "black." Those who would argue that the great American civilizations arise from a black African origin make the same assumption that the Native Americans were incapable of creating these great cultures on their own.

More significantly, recent archaeological finds have pushed back the dates of first occupation and raised interesting possibilities of transoceanic contacts. More and more finds, such as those at Monte Verde in Chile, and the discovery of skeletal remains in the state of Washington, make it harder and harder to hold to the Asiatic immigrants after 12,000 B.C. theory. Clearly, the dates are going to be pushed back, and there is growing evidence for the presence of non-Asiatic influences and genes. Nevertheless, I will stand by the gist of the traditional explanation. I still believe that the Asian migrants formed the basic genetic stock of the Native Americans, but there probably were some transoceanic contacts. They were just not fundamental to cultural developments. I believe that these transoceanic arrivals were not only possible, but that some did make the voyages. There was not, however, a back and forth exchange. The (very small) traffic was all "inbound."

VARIETIES OF CULTURES

An amazing array of cultures and peoples emerged in the Americas before 1492, and there are many different frameworks for grouping Native American peoples. Some of the most important have divided these peoples by language groups, levels of political organization, or by their relationships to ecological systems. Using language groups is fairly non-controversial, but it does not tell us much about differences among the many diverse peoples. We need to categorize so we can differentiate among the many cultures, but we must be very careful not to fall into the dangerous moral judgments of the nineteenth century that assumed some sort of moral superiority for the more highly organized groups. Looking at the complexity of political organization tells us a great deal about differences, but does not necessarily lead us to judgments of moral superiority or inferiority. One of the great advantages of the ecological analysis is that it divides peoples up by how they respond to their environments, and provides us with useful ways to understand varying levels of social, economic, and political organization.

I will use a simple scheme, first suggested by the eminent historian James Lockhart, that divides all the native peoples into three basic types.

The first of these groups is "nonsedentary" or nomadic peoples. These are very small groups that live by hunting and gathering. With few members, they do not produce a surplus of food. These tribes cannot develop even the most basic social divisions: gender roles, age divisions, someone recognized for their special religious powers, such as a shaman. Good examples of nonsedentary peoples are the Cheyenne and Apaches of the Great Plains of North America and the C  peoples in the forests and prairies of eastern South America.

"Semisedentary" peoples settle for periods in a single location, but then move on to new lands. They develop some limited knowledge of domesticating animals and growing crops. They may have dogs, or herding animals, and basic knowledge about planting some crops. This rudimentary form of agriculture produces a small surplus. "Slash-and-burn" agriculture is typical of many semisedentary peoples. Sometimes called swidden agriculture, it involves clearing the forest with stone tools, and then burning everything. This is, on a small scale, the same procedure employed on a massive scale in Amazonia today to deforest the region. The ash serves as fertilizer, but after a couple of seasons the poor tropical soils force the tribes to move on and repeat the process. In an era of small, widely dispersed tribes, the forest eventually grows back and the millions of acres of tropical forest could support slash-and-burn indefinitely. Even this low level of agricultural productivity frees some to engage in activities other than food production. Tribes can grow into the hundreds, with many families and large huts. Groups sometimes grow large enough to split or fission into two separate groups. The division of labor becomes more complex, but still limited to hunters, those who tend the crops (generally women), and those with special religious duties. Good examples of semisedentary peoples are the Tup , who once inhabited the long coastal region of Brazil, and the peoples of the Brazilian rain forest who continue to live this way. The Yanomami, who today straddle the Brazilian-Venezuelan border, are perhaps the most famous example. They provide us with a glimpse of how many of the native peoples of lowland regions probably lived for thousands of years.

"Sedentary" peoples, as the name suggests, are rooted in a single place on a permanent basis. These are cultures that have mastered the domestication of plants and animals. They joined the exclusive group of peoples in the Old World who moved into sophisticated manipulation of their surrounding environment. Unlike those in the Old World, however, the sedentary peoples of the Americas had no large beasts of burden—no horses, oxen, water buffalo, or pack animals. (As Jared Diamond has pointed out, this absence of large domesticated animals also probably shielded the Native Americans from the kinds of diseases that developed in the Old World. Smallpox, plague, and the like seem to have arisen in

domesticated animals and then spread to the domesticators.) The development of more accomplished agriculture allows the population of sedentary peoples to grow and to develop very complex social structures. Rather than remaining in the hundreds, tribes could grow into the thousands and tens of thousands with the production of greater and greater surpluses of food. As in industrial societies today, greater productivity per farmer freed more and more people to leave farming and engage in a wide array of non-food-producing activities.

Although the most sophisticated of these sedentary peoples had complex social structures and urban centers, I should emphasize that (as in Europe) the vast majority of the people continued to live on the land in the countryside. But the shift to settled agriculture was a revolutionary one, just as it had been in the Old World. Some good examples of these sedentary peoples are the tribes in the eastern woodlands of North America, or the Arawaks in the Caribbean. Agriculture had developed enough in these regions to produce networks of villages and tribes. Although not as complex as the three greatest empires in the Americas, these societies did form chiefdoms and confederations that enlarged their power and ability to make war and dominate others. When Columbus arrived in the Caribbean, it was large villages and chiefdoms that he encountered, peoples in between the great empires, on the one hand, and hunters and gatherers, on the other.

HIGH CIVILIZATIONS: MAYAS, AZTECS, INCAS

The most highly developed of the sedentary peoples were the Mayas, Aztecs, and Incas. The first to develop were the Mayas, who reached two "peaks" (A.D. 250–900 and A.D. 1200–1450) in two different areas of Mesoamerica. As with all great civilizations, although the eventual focal point of development was in a particular region (southern Mexico, Guatemala, Honduras, and El Salvador) the Maya arose out of the convergence and borrowing over centuries of many techniques and practices in Mesoamerica. The great "mother" culture of Mesoamerica was that of the Olmecs, who flourished along the Gulf of Mexico from about 1200 to 400 B.C. Many of the peoples of Mesoamerica inherited from the Olmecs their religious traditions, notions of time, and artistic styles. After the decline of the Olmecs, and up until around A.D. 900, central Mexico became a powerful cultural influence across the region, first from the great city of Teotihuacan (on the outskirts of present-day Mexico City) and then Tula, the home of the Toltecs.

What is perhaps most striking about the Maya is how intensively they exploited the extremely inhospitable lowland forests of Guatemala and

southern Mexico. In contrast to the great river civilizations of the Middle East and Asia, the Maya overcame extraordinary ecological challenges to create a very sophisticated and productive agriculture that was the key to their development. The Aztecs (central Mexico) and the Incas (Ecuador, Peru, Bolivia) were late bloomers, emerging as impressive empires in the fifteenth century. In each case, the focal point of development was eventually at altitudes above 7,000 to 8,000 feet and through the harnessing of waters from lakes and mountain streams and rivers. For both the Aztecs and the Incas, the empires were the culmination of centuries of agricultural and cultural developments. All three civilizations (Aztecs, Incas, Maya) shared common features: highly sophisticated irrigation and farming, complex social and cultural organization, sophisticated calendar and astronomical knowledge, highly developed religions, and militant ideologies of conquest and empire-building. When the Europeans encountered the Aztecs and the Incas, they confronted peoples who were their equals in nearly all realms of life.

The earliest Americans had begun to make tools and settle into villages by 8000 B.C., in the period often called Paleo-Indian (just a fancy way of saying "old Indian") or the Archaic. Unlike the people of the Old World, the peoples of the Americas had no large draft animals (except the rather finicky llamas and alpacas in the Andes), and they never developed the use of the wheel, plows, iron, or the so-called true keystone arch. The earliest tools that appear are named after the site of Clovis, New Mexico, where archaeologists first found them. During several thousand years, humans spread out across all of the Americas, living largely by hunting, fishing, and gathering. From about 8000 to 2500 B.C., in the Archaic period, we see the first signs of agriculture, simple pottery, and the domestication of maize and the potato.

At least four places emerge as centers for the development of agriculture in the Americas: Mesoamerica, the Andes, Amazonia, and possibly in the Caribbean basin. Over the next two thousand years, the cultures that form the basis of the great civilizations begin to take shape in Mesoamerica and the Andes, with the origins of sophisticated agriculture, social stratification, and the emergence of the first great ceremonial centers.

Agriculture was the key to the emergence of complex civilizations in the Americas, just as it was in the Old World in China, India, Egypt, and Mesopotamia. These cultures not only developed sophisticated means of domesticating plants and animals; they also developed elaborate systems of irrigation that formed the backbone of the emerging states and empires. Water is the key to agriculture, and control of water requires increasingly sophisticated organization of people and political power. In central Mexico this meant controlling the waters of Lake Texcoco around what became the Aztec capital of Tenochtitlan. In the Andean world it meant

controlling the water coming down out of the high mountains. In the words of a famous scholar of the 1950s, Karl Wittfogel, these were "hydraulic" civilizations. The central crops were maize in Mesoamerica and potatoes in the Andes. Both are indigenous to the Americas and today form two of the four major crops that feed the vast majority of the world's population. (The other two are Old World crops—rice and wheat.) In the Caribbean basin and lowland South America, the main crop was a tuber that went by many names and varieties: yucca, manioc, or cassava. The peoples of Mesoamerica also domesticated cacao (chocolate), various squashes and chilis, and pineapple, all crops that did not exist in the Old World.

As we have seen, the Maya were the first of these three great civilizations to emerge. Maya civilization was, in reality, a series of city-states and empires that rose and fell over nearly 2000 years. Unlike the Aztecs and the Incas, the Maya never constructed a unified and extensive empire. Across Mesoamerica, several key cultures emerged in the formative or pre-Classic period from 2500 B.C. to A.D. 250. During this era, the Maya developed a sedentary society around sophisticated agriculture and the domestication of plants and animals. They also developed fine pottery, weaving, and stone work. The first great ceremonial centers emerged, especially in the central highlands of Guatemala. With their linear and angular architecture, these centers became the origins of Maya city-states. An intensive agriculture made possible the rise of urban centers that contained upwards of 50,000 inhabitants. As in Spain and Portugal, Maya society was built on hierarchy and inequality, with a small class of nobles and an enormous class of commoners who lived and worked on the land. Like the Old World societies, the Maya had a complex social hierarchy based on wealth, prestige, and family lineage. Slavery was also a part of Maya society, especially the enslavement of war captives.

The first Maya civilization reached full development during the Classic period, from about A.D. 250 to 900. All the accomplishments for which the Maya are known flourished during these centuries. This is the era of the great explosion of artistic, intellectual, and architectural endeavors. In particular, building on the achievements of the Olmecs, the Maya developed an impressive astronomical knowledge that rivaled that of the Old World, and a form of mathematics based on a vigesimal system (based on the number 20, not 10). The Maya had two calendars that moved in sync over centuries. One was a solar calendar divided into 18 months with 20 days each, concluding with 5 days of dread and uncertainty at the end of each year. The other was divided into 13 months with 20 days each. These calendars began at the same mythical moment of origin, and every 52 (365-day) solar years, both ended at the same time in a period of tremendous uncertainty and foreboding. In addition, the Maya maintained what

archaeologists have dubbed a "long count" calendar that began at the moment of creation—3114 B.C. on the Christian calendar. The Maya also developed a writing system, which was rare among the native peoples of the Americas. Based on a system of glyphs, most surviving examples are carved into the stone monuments of Mesoamerica, and these public statements provide us with an official history of Maya nobles and kings. The Spanish systematically hunted down and destroyed Maya "books" during the sixteenth century and only four of these have survived.

Perhaps the most famous symbols of this era are the restored ruins of great pyramids and palaces where the nobles and priests staged elaborate religious and political rituals. Most striking are the steeply stepped pyramids with their temples at the top. Amazingly, the Maya built these great stone cities with no beasts of burden and no metal tools. The exploitation of human labor must have been enormous. The partially restored ruins at Tikal in Guatemala and Palenque in southern Mexico are prime examples of the power and glory of the massive Maya structures. Only three of the pyramids in the region have yielded royal tombs. Bloodletting and drug-induced trances were central to the religious worldview of the Maya, and these temples served as the primary locus of religious ritual and cosmology. Some of the most powerful scenes from surviving paintings and carvings show Maya nobles drawing blood through the ritual mutilation of their own tongues and genitals. This sacrificial blood offered to the gods helped keep the great cycle of life moving forward.

One of the great mysteries of pre-Columbian America is the collapse of Classic civilizations all across Mesoamerica around A.D. 900. Scholars have suggested a variety of causes: disease, ecological disaster, and war, but none has achieved any kind of consensus. After the demise of the great city-states across Mesoamerica, another great Maya civilization emerges in the lowlands of the Yucatán peninsula and northern Guatemala after A.D. 1200 and collapses in the mid-1400s. In the so-called Post-Classic period, we see the rise of the great city-states such as Chichén Itzá and Uxmal in northern Guatemala and the Yucatán. These cities and their architecture have clear influences from the Classic cultures of central Mexico, the most visible example being the presence of the "feathered serpent" known as Kukulkán in the Yucatán and Quetzalcóatl in central Mexico. The most powerful of these city-states was Mayapán, which was at the peak of its power from around A.D. 1200 to 1450. This second great Maya period, however, ended nearly a half-century before the arrival of the Spanish invaders, probably a victim of intense civil wars among competing city-states. With their sophisticated knowledge of astronomy, mathematics, calendars, and a writing system, the Maya are perhaps the most impressive of the three high civilizations of the Americas. Yet, the lack of any overarching imperial authority after 1450 left the Maya much

more dispersed and decentralized than the Incas or the Aztecs. Ironically, this may have made them more difficult to conquer than their other two counterparts.

The Aztecs emerge late in the post-Classic period (A.D. 900–1500) in the Valley of Mexico. They built on the great cultural accomplishments of the Maya and other Mesoamerican peoples. In particular, they consciously traced their lineage back to the Toltecs of Tula, a city that sat on the periphery of the Valley of Mexico. Toltec power had peaked around the year A.D. 1000 under the ruler Quetzalcóatl. In Aztec cosmology, Quetzalcóatl was expelled from Tula and he was expected to return some day to reclaim his kingdom. (The year of his expected return in the Aztec calendar coincided with the year 1519 on the Christian calendar.) The Toltec state collapsed in the twelfth century, but its influence was widespread across central Mexico. The Aztecs probably arrived in the region at about the time of the collapse of Toltec power. They were a nomadic people who settled around a lake in the Valley of Mexico in the twelfth century. As the old founding myth goes, they left their original homeland of Aztlan (probably in what would become the Southwest of the United States) and their gods had instructed them to settle when they found an eagle perched on a cactus with a serpent in his beak. (This is now the symbol on the Mexican flag.) After serving as mercenaries, they forged alliances with other cities around the marshy lake and began to build their own center, Tenochtitlan, on an island in the lake in the mid-fourteenth century. (Speaking Nahuatl, these people are more accurately known as the Mexica or Nahuas, but I will use their more familiar name here. The region the Spanish would eventually refer to as Mexico was the homeland of the Mexica.) In the fifteenth century under Itzcoatl, they began to expand outwards, forging a "triple alliance" with the nearby cities of Texcoco and Tlacopan. Eventually, they reduced their two allies to subordinates and within fifty years conquered nearly all of central Mexico from coast to coast. Only a few peoples managed to resist domination, most notably the Tlaxcalans to the east of Tenochtitlan. Unlike the Incas, the Aztecs did not develop an extensive bureaucratic system. They preferred to extract tribute and to let local rulers serve as their intermediaries. As they became increasingly powerful in the fifteenth century, they destroyed their old histories and rewrote their "official" history to link their origins directly to the celebrated Toltecs.

Their complex religion required them to offer fresh human blood to appease the war god, Huitzilopochtli (often translated as "hummingbird on the left" or "hummingbird from the south"). In the Aztec worldview, Huitzilopochtli and the warrior sun, Tonatiuh, are engaged in a perpetual struggle against the stars. To fuel this fight, and to keep the sun moving across the sky each day, Huitzilopochtli and Tonatiuh require fresh human

blood. The pursuit of blood from larger and larger numbers of sacrificial victims both drives and accompanies empire-building. When the great pyramid in Tenochtitlan was dedicated in 1487, the Aztecs are believed to have ritually slaughtered as many as twenty thousand victims. The empire reached its peak in the early sixteenth century under Montezuma II, who ascended to the throne in 1502.

As in other major civilizations, intensive agriculture made the growth and diversification of their society possible. Through the construction of extensive dams, canals, and flood channels, the Aztecs harnessed the waters of the Valley of Mexico. In the surrounding lakes they developed a system of "gardens" that were, in effect, fertile patches of land built up by filling in small sections of the lake with soil and vegetation. These patches (or *chinampas*) were built in gridlike patterns with canals running through them. Perhaps as many as one hundred thousand farmers worked in the *chinampas* by the time of the Conquest. The highly productive agriculture of the Valley of Mexico and the spoils of empire fueled the growth of Tenochtitlan. By 1519 the city had perhaps a quarter of a million inhabitants. Massive stone temples rose above the central plaza and eight major canals crisscrossed the city. A series of major causeways connected the island capital with the lakeshores to the north, west, and south.

The Incas also emerged as a great empire in the fifteenth century. The development of the Inca empire parallels many of the developments in Mesoamerica. Several cultures developed in the two millennia before the Incas and contributed to the key elements of their civilization. One of the most important of these precursors emerged around Chavín de Huántar, a city above 10,000 feet in northern Peru. Chavín flourished at roughly the same time as the Olmecs and developed complex architectural styles, textiles, and religious practices that would diffuse across the Andean region. The most distinctive feature of Chavín's artwork is a feline being (most likely originating from the influence of the Amazonian lowlands and its jaguar cults) whose impact can be seen throughout the Andean world. The Mochica, on the arid northern Peruvian coast, played the role of Teotihuacan and Tula from about A.D. 200 to 700. They developed an impressive empire with sophisticated pottery, metallurgy, pyramids, and irrigation systems. While Chavín and the Mochica thrived in the north and the coastal lowlands, after A.D. 600 the most important influences in the Andean world were in the central highlands—at Tiahuanaco on the high plain around Lake Titicaca in modern-day Bolivia, and the Wari Empire radiating outward from the area around Ayacucho in southern Peru. By around A.D. 1000, both the Mochica and Chavín civilizations had disintegrated. Another powerful new group—the Chimú—emerged in the mid-thirteenth century and their influence would be widespread until they were conquered by the Incas in the mid-fifteenth century. Their capital

at Chan-Chan in the arid northern Peruvian coastal lowlands may have had a population of some 150,000.

Like the Aztecs, the Incas had humble origins in the mid-thirteenth century in a small village called Cuzco in the southern highlands of modern-day Peru. Their rise was even quicker and more sweeping than that of the Aztecs. Beginning in the 1430s under Pachacuti Inca and his son, Topa Inca, they moved outwards from Cuzco, conquering the *altiplano* in Bolivia, the cities of the coastal lowlands (including Chan-Chan), and as far north as the highlands of modern-day Ecuador. By the early sixteenth century, the Inca empire stretched from Ecuador to northern Chile and Argentina and across the highlands of Bolivia. Somewhere between five to ten million people fell under Inca rule. As with the Aztecs, Inca expansion essentially halted at the fringes of sedentary society. The equivalent of the deserts and nomads of northern Mexico for the Incas were the tropical hunters and gatherers of the lowlands east of the Andes.

Inca civilization developed at very high altitudes in the Andes (above 8,000 feet). The terrain of the region is stunning, with towering mountains rising very quickly from an arid coast. Steep river valleys cut through the mountains, bringing the melting snowpack down to the coast. Like the Mesoamericans, the Incas developed a very sophisticated terraced agriculture. The so-called "Irish" potato, in fact, is native to the Andes and, like maize in Mesoamerica, became the primary foodstuff. The Incas also raised maize. They raised alpacas and llamas to serve as beasts of burden, and to provide meat and wool. Small rodents, known to us today as guinea pigs, were native to the region and provided another basic food source.

The Incas developed a complex religion with many gods and an imperial ideology. More so than in Mesoamerica, the Incas pursued a process of cultural imperialism. As they conquered peoples and forced them to pay tribute, they also imposed on them their language (Quechua) and religion. As with all great empires, the Incas both imposed their own gods and, along the way, absorbed many of the gods and practices of those they conquered. In the Bolivian *altiplano*, they facilitated the spread of the other major indigenous language in the Andes, Aymara. They built the most extensive empire in the Americas. Astonishingly, the Incas ran this vast empire without any system of writing. An extensive and impressive road system linked all regions of the empire and an enormous bureaucracy. Two main roads, one along the coast and another in the mountains, ran from the northern to the southern fringes of the empire. A series of roads running east-west connected up these two great axes of transportation. Some of the Inca bridges across deep mountain gorges survived into the nineteenth century, and sections of these roads are still in use. The Incas imposed a forced rotary draft labor system (known as the *mit'a*) to build

and maintain roads, bridges, public buildings, and an extensive network of granaries.

The northern capital of the empire was in Quito (contemporary Ecuador) and the southern capital in Cuzco (present-day Peru). As in central Mexico, the basic social unit was a sort of clan or *ayllu*. In a vast system of reciprocity, the *ayllu* provided labor for the empire and the state provided the *ayllu* with goods, especially foodstuffs. Civil war broke out in this vast empire shortly before the arrival of the Spanish. After the death of Huayna Cápac (possibly from smallpox) in 1525, two of the Inca ruler's many sons, Huáscar and Atahualpa, engaged in a bloody struggle for control of the empire. This struggle over control of the Inca Empire would play into the hands of the Spanish and facilitate the conquest of the Incas.

3

Iberians and Africans

Three continents—Africa, Europe, and Asia—formed the “Old World,” and for thousands of years the peoples of these continents developed in almost complete isolation from the peoples of the Americas. In the ancient and medieval worlds the Mediterranean Sea formed the center of an economic and political network that linked Europe, North Africa, and the Middle East. The primary axes of trade came out of the East (the Indian Ocean and China, across the Middle East, then across the eastern Mediterranean), and the South (from sub-Saharan Africa northward across the desert) to the cities of the Italian peninsula. In turn, this trade then moved across the Mediterranean and the European continent to the Atlantic, the North Sea, and the Baltic. Goods and peoples moved back and forth along this dense and complex set of trading networks that ultimately linked the major cultures and peoples of the Old World. Gold and ivory from sub-Saharan Africa, spices from the Indian Ocean, silks from East Asia, and silver from central Europe were just a few of the most important goods moving along these trade routes.

In the fifteenth century, the city-states of Florence, Genoa, and Venice were among the most vibrant and dynamic trading centers in the world, as goods flowed out of Asia, across the Middle East, into the eastern Mediterranean, and then to the Italian peninsula. In the second half of the thirteenth century, when Marco Polo, his father, and his uncle left Venice, they moved across Iran to the Persian Gulf, then to Kashgar in central Asia. From there they took the old Silk Road across China to Peking. Another major trade route connected Peking with Canton in south China and then Malacca in the “Spice Islands” (what we today call Indonesia and the East Indies). From there, ships moved to southwestern India, where traders